

Funding issues and development of digital libraries in Nigeria

*Titilola Aminat Bayero Abdussalam, Janet Oluseyi Adewara,
Jamiu Wankasi Abdulraheem, Tunde Toyese Oyedokun and Tawakalitu Raufu Balogun*

Introduction

Digital libraries include networked information databases containing digital contents in various formats with several points of information entry available. The effort geared toward improving information services with the use of computers and information technologies serves as a precursor for the development of a digital library. The dream of digital library development comes to fruition most importantly with the emergence of the internet that enables browsing and navigation of information resources on websites and information databases.

Information resources deposited in digital libraries are in an electronic format that is either born-digital, that is electronically generated or those that are converted from their original forms through the digitization policy of the library. Digital libraries adopt electronic information storage with vast amounts of information that increase easy and rapid access. Digital libraries also serve as information archives. Unfortunately, in Nigeria, digital libraries have the high cost of developing and maintaining terabytes of information storage, network server, internet connectivity, collection development management, ownership, license and subscription cost of fees-based electronic information resources and cost of training library staff and users.

Libraries in Nigeria are gradually and steadily migrating from traditional library services to more computerized services and more specifically digitization library services. This paper explores issues in obtaining and allocating funds for the development of digital libraries in Nigeria, justifying the transition toward digital transformation and ways of obtaining necessary funds

for the development of the project even in the face of ever-increasing library budget cuts.

Prospects and benefits of digital library services

A digital library is a viable proposition to the preservation of library information resources even to print information resources that can be converted into digital format through scanning and retrospective migration (Kato *et al.*, 2020). The need for digital library services arises because of the emergence of digital content and the ever-increasing workload involved in coping with the information explosion keeping pace with the capacity to curate the ever-increasing digital information on the internet. Digital libraries provide access to information regardless of where the information is stored with greater speed and accuracy.

Digital library service tends to solve age-long library challenges of financial crunch as well as opportunity to conform to technology growth in society. Digital library further enhance library consortia through networking and interconnected information resource sharing among cooperating libraries that broaden access to vast information resources at a lower cost. One of the main features of the digital library is an online search that enables users to access both the bibliographic information and full-text document once there is a match between search terms and document descriptor sometimes refers to as metadata (McGinty, 2021). Online information search is interactive and a sustainable opportunity of information material acquisition, information processing on integrated library systems (ILS) and electronic transmission and circulation of digital information resources.

The burgeoning technological development in today's digital environment in which libraries operate foster self-access user's interface services on secured library digital space that enable users to be independent information searchers and conversely promoting information literacy (Burke, 2013). Digital content broadens the range of information resources and also added value to them. Digital library operates in cyberspace of digital environment by extending hours of access indefinite, thereby coalescing the accomplishment of the traditional library that has a definite opening and closing hour of service.

Digital library development at its best would normally require a library website with a database management system to host digital information resources, user's interface for web-based access to information resources, digitization and capturing of local content and provision of links to licensed external information databases (Xia, 2013). Furthermore, a library management system (LMS) also refers to as ILS is usually integrated with digital information repositories or databases to manage content assets in various electronic and digital multimedia formats. The best LMS is a more encompassing one that integrates the management of collection development, allow patrons to access information from online public access catalogue, keeping track of user's profiles, past and present loans and member's subscription, as well as library statistics.

Funding issues with the development of digital libraries in Nigeria

As immensely beneficial digital library services are to both the librarians and community of users, libraries in Nigeria is still struggling to develop digital library services and obviously, financial constraints posed to be the

major problem. Libraries in Nigeria are known to suffer draconian budget cuts whenever the country economy is in distress, in the interval, inflation and the high cost of ICT tools can make digital library development prohibitively expensive. As a result, most libraries in Nigeria operate hybrid library services, as complete digitization of information resources cannot be done in the short-term and most importantly users are yet to give up on print media. The dream of a paperless society is still at the infant stage in Nigeria. For the most part, libraries in Nigeria are not given priority and proper consideration when it comes to allocation of budget. Evidence to that is the case of the National Library of Nigeria that is still under construction for more than a decade, and if the government did not deem it fit to prioritize finance for the completion of the apex library in Nigeria, then what chance do other libraries have. More so, since the virulent spread of the COVID-19 pandemic, libraries have further witness shortfall in their statutory budget allocation that has taken tolls on library projects.

The complexity of digital library development represents a wide range of barriers to its implementation. Digital divide for instance is a problem that manifested in multiple folds that can be due to social exclusion, absence of information infrastructure in some remote less urban and rural areas, disparity between individuals with proficiency in information literacy and those that are not, and the ability to afford a computer or mobile device to remotely access digital information. In Nigeria, citizen's lack of trust in government also extends to other institutions that indirectly affect library policy voice and subsequently far-less funding support for the library. The decline in civic engagement of the populace also comes with a loss of advocacy for proper funding of the library (Smith, 2019). Underfunding of the library in Nigeria is perennial and any digital libraries projects in Nigeria failed majorly due to inaccurate costing of information infrastructure and facilities needed for digital library operation. Besides, wrong selection of library software, absence of proper system analysis and dearth of trained

library personnel are some other factors that account for digital library project failure in Nigeria.

Most libraries with digital library services in Nigeria are in academic and special libraries that have a moderate level of financing from their parent institutions. It is hoped that stakeholders responsible for the management of libraries wake up to their responsibility of providing sufficient funds for the library to activate digital library services that are expected of a modern-day library. University libraries in Nigeria have witnessed great initiative toward the development of digital library services, with the federal ministry of education through the national university commission establishing a National Virtual Library to make digitally available all locally produced information resources in the country to bolster the quality of education and information service in Nigeria. Another giant stride toward the development of the digital library is the National Open University Digital Library, UNESCO Virtual Library Pilot Project and e-libraries established in various institutions and organizations. With the growth of the telecommunication industry in Nigeria, Nigerian libraries received donations and commissioning of e-library across the board (Ishola, 2014).

The first success story of digital library services in Nigeria is that of the International Institute of Tropical Agriculture library, Ibadan in 1984 with an ILS that includes acquisition, cataloging and circulation of digital information resources. At the moment, many are libraries that have digitized their operations, but one cannot say with absolute certainty the number of Nigerian libraries that have fully or partially migrated to digital library operation. But nevertheless, majorly all the university libraries in Nigeria are operating hybrid kind of library services. Meanwhile, university libraries, such as Kenneth Dike Library, University of Ibadan, Ibadan; Hezekiah Oluwasanmi Library, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife; University of Ilorin Library, Ilorin; Ladoko Akintola University of Technology Library, Ogbomoso; Albert Ilemobade Library, Federal University of Technology, Akure and many more, have gotten their digital library service right to a high extent. Special and research libraries operating

digital library services in Nigeria include but not limited to the National Center for Economic Management and Administration Library, Bodija, Ibadan; Nigerian Institute of International Affairs Library, Victoria Island, Lagos and Central Bank of Nigeria Library, Lagos. Even though the list is not exhaustive but yet the rate of digital library development is still low considering the number of libraries in the country.

University libraries in Nigeria receive a 10% budgetary allocation from the university budget, government special intervention through Tertiary Education Trust Fund for the library project, as well as funds from international organizations, foundations and individual donors. But even with these allocated funds, university librarians are not given free hand to decide how much is allocated to library projects, as vice-chancellors stand in the position of the university accounting officers and also consider library fund as part of their statutory control (Ishola, 2014). The foregoing make it necessary for university library stakeholders to be educated on value digital library posed to provide. For instance, an institutional repository help expose the university's scholarly publications to the global audience, which is useful for the image and academic ranking of the university at the global stage, as well as in the recruitment of new students. Digital library services also help to extend information services to faculty members and students in distance learning centers. Educating graduate students on the important of open access initiative can help make them ambassadors of library efforts. The support of the alumni can as well be sought for library project, more specifically for the development of digital library project.

The main sources of funds for libraries in Nigeria are budgetary allocation in form of subvention, a grant from donors and library charges for user's registration and some other special services. Other creative way of sourcing fund for digital library project is through crowd-funding that facilitate online donation from individuals or organizations willing to support library project. Crowd-funding is an online fundraising platform, such as Kickstarter, FUNDLY, Airfunding, Naijafund, Indiegogo, GoFundMe and

many more. Although, GoFundMe is currently not in Nigeria, but libraries in Nigeria can still leverage the platform by getting someone in supporting countries to raise the charity funding on behalf of the library.

Concluding remark

Libraries in Nigeria have already set the course for next major transition into the future to meet the evolving needs of today Google generation set of users. Meanwhile, in response to the dynamism of the digital world and information age, Nigerian libraries strive to render high-tech library services in the face of stringent finances. The library of the future has already materialized in form of digital library services, but the cost of developing a digital library is not foreseeable cheap, it will surely strain the library finances, but in the end the benefit out weight the cost implications. Financial support can be solicited from local and international organizations, foundations and individual donors whose interest aligns with that of the library. They can make do with internal and external arrangements for information resources sharing, part ownership of information access, outsourcing of services and subsidy from ILS and technologies providers or through a strategic alliance with technology innovation companies willing to develop and test their new technology product in a library setting. Testament to this is the fact that some open-source library application software, such as DSpace, KOHA and Greenstone are grant-aided projects. Succinctly, if Nigerian libraries are to play an active role in world digital trends, the issue of the digital divide must be tackled head-on by bridging the divide and yarning gaps of information infrastructure development across the country.

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Titilola Aminat Bayero Abdussalam (abdussalam.tab@unilorun.edu.ng), **Janet Oluseyi Adewara** (omoniyi.jo@unilorin.edu.ng) and **Jamiu Wankasi Abdulraheem** (abdulraheemjamiuwankasi@gmail.com) are all based at Library Department, University of Ilorin, Ilorin, Nigeria.

Tunde Toyese Oyedokun (toyex4eternity@gmail.com) is based at the Department of Library and Information Science, Faculty of Communication and Information Sciences, University of Ilorin, Ilorin, Nigeria.

Tawakalitu Raufu Balogun (balogun.tr@unilorin.edu.ng) is based at Library Department, University of Ilorin, Ilorin, Nigeria.